

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 192

By Akbari

A RESOLUTION to recognize and honor Priscilla Presley.

WHEREAS, it is the privilege of the members of this General Assembly to recognize those Tennesseans who have made a lasting impact on this State through their extraordinary achievements, dedication, and leadership; and

WHEREAS, one such individual is Priscilla Presley, whose unwavering commitment to preserving and promoting the legacy of Elvis Presley, Memphis music, and the State of Tennessee and her various charitable endeavors can only be categorized as outstanding; and

WHEREAS, born in New York, Priscilla Presley spent her early years traveling with her family, courtesy of her father's career as an Air Force officer; soon after settling in Del Valle, Texas, the family was transferred to Wiesbaden, West Germany, where Priscilla Beaulieu met her future husband, Elvis Presley, in 1960; and

WHEREAS, the couple eventually married in 1967, and their only child, Lisa Marie Presley, was born in 1968; despite their divorce in 1973, Priscilla and Elvis Presley maintained a close relationship until his untimely death in 1977; and

WHEREAS, following the passing of Elvis's father, Vernon Presley, Ms. Presley took on the role of co-executor of Elvis Presley's estate, demonstrating remarkable tenacity and leadership; and

WHEREAS, Priscilla Presley faced immense pressure from legal advisors to sell Graceland, yet she stood firm in her conviction, declaring, "That will never happen. We're not selling Graceland," and set forth on a mission to preserve and enhance the legacy of the Presley family; and

WHEREAS, her diligent efforts, research, and determination led to a successful partnership with Jack Soden and the subsequent transformation of Graceland into a world-renowned historic landmark and tourist destination; and

WHEREAS, aside from the quest to save Graceland, Priscilla Presley continued her own career and entrepreneurship; in 1980, her love of animals and commitment to their protection led her to host *Those Amazing Animals*, a unique and educational television show that served as a precursor to today's *Animal Planet*; and

WHEREAS, in 1983, Ms. Presley took on the role of Jenna Wade in the popular CBS evening television drama *Dallas*, becoming an instant audience favorite and one of the show's most popular leading ladies, seen by over 300 million viewers worldwide each week; and

WHEREAS, Priscilla Presley displayed her comedic talents in the 1988 box office smash *The Naked Gun: From the Files of Police Squad* and reprised her role in *The Naked Gun 2½* and *The Naked Gun 33 1/3: The Final Insult*; she also starred in the films *Breakfast with Einstein* and *Haley Wagner Star* and guest-starred on television's *Melrose Place*, *Touched by an Angel*, and *Spin City*; and

WHEREAS, for ten years, Ms. Presley starred on British stages with acting legend Warwick Davis in pantomimes, including *Aladdin* and *Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs*, with her favorite role being the Wicked Witch in *Snow White*; and

WHEREAS, her business acumen has been proven through successful entrepreneurial ventures in linens, fragrances, film and music production, and public speaking, in addition to her ongoing dedication to Graceland; and

WHEREAS, Graceland was prepared for public opening with a \$560,000 investment, which was recouped only thirty-eight days after its opening on June 7, 1982; in the years since, Graceland has attracted over 22 million guests to Memphis, becoming the second-most visited

residence in the United States (after the White House) and creating an economic impact of over \$6 billion since its opening; and

WHEREAS, through the efforts of Priscilla Presley, Graceland was listed in the National Register of Historic Places in 1991 and was designated a National Historic Landmark in 2006; she has worked tirelessly to preserve Graceland Mansion, its grounds, and countless artifacts belonging to Elvis Presley, ensuring its enduring popularity and significance; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Presley's dedication to preserving Graceland and promoting it globally for the past forty years has firmly established Memphis as the world's preeminent rock and roll mecca, with Graceland serving as a gateway to the rich musical heritage of Memphis; and

WHEREAS, the music that emanated out of Memphis, including that of Elvis Presley, changed the planet, with curators of the Smithsonian Institution noting that the world learned the English language by singing the lyrics of songs by Elvis and other musicians from Memphis; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Presley has served as an international ambassador for Elvis, Memphis, and Memphis music, promoting projects, opening exhibits, and enhancing global recognition of Memphis's musical heritage; and

WHEREAS, in 2018, she produced the critically acclaimed HBO documentary *Elvis Presley: The Searcher*, which artistically narrated Elvis's life through his music; and

WHEREAS, with the release of Baz Luhrmann's movie *Elvis* in 2022, Priscilla Presley traveled to several premieres and international events, further promoting the legacy of Elvis and Memphis music and contributing to exhibitions and performances globally; and

WHEREAS, in 2023, the biographical drama film *Priscilla*, co-produced by Priscilla Presley and based on her memoir *Elvis and Me*, continued to highlight her impactful life and career; and

WHEREAS, Priscilla Presley continues to advocate for animal protection charities and serves as spokesperson for the Dream Foundation; she has given her time and support at the

Tennessee Capitol for the expansion of exhibits and the educational mission of the Smithsonian-curated Memphis Rock 'n' Soul Museum to relocate to a prominent centerstage in the historic Lansky building on the iconic Beale Street, further contributing to the preservation and future of Memphis's rich musical heritage; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that, more than six decades after Elvis Presley was honored with the Governor's Colonel Aide-de-Camp award, the highest civilian honor in the State of Tennessee, in March 1961, we are pleased to honor Ms. Priscilla Beaulieu Presley, another Tennessee treasure, upon her receipt of the Colonel Aide-de-Camp award for her outstanding contributions and unwavering dedication to preserving and promoting the legacy of Elvis Presley, Memphis music, and the State of Tennessee and applaud her distinguished career in the entertainment industry as we recognize March as Women's History Month.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.